

Transfer Balance Account Reporting (TBAR)

What is Transfer Balance Account Reporting (TBAR)?

Transfer Balance Account Reporting (TBAR) is how your SMSF tells the ATO when certain pension events occur. This helps the ATO keep track of how much of your Transfer Balance Cap has been used.

To understand TBAR, it helps to know these three terms:

Transfer Balance Cap (TBC)

The Transfer Balance Cap is the maximum amount of super that can be moved into retirement phase (pension phase).

Each person has their own cap, which may vary depending on when they first started a retirement phase pension.

Transfer Balance Account (TBA)

The Transfer Balance Account is a record kept by the ATO of all your retirement phase pension transactions.

Think of it like a running balance:

- Starting a pension increases the balance.
- Stopping or commuting a pension decreases the balance.

The ATO uses this account to monitor how much of your Transfer Balance Cap has been used.

Transfer Balance Account Report (TBAR)

A TBAR is the report sent to the ATO when certain pension events occur.

Examples include:

- Starting a retirement phase pension.
- Partially or fully commuting a pension.
- Certain death benefit pensions.

The information reported updates your Transfer Balance Account and helps the ATO ensure you do not exceed your Transfer Balance Cap.

Is my Transition to Retirement Income Stream (TRIS) affected by these rules?

A TRIS allows you to access some of your super after reaching preservation age, even if you have not fully retired.

If you are under age 65 and have not fully retired, your TRIS is generally not counted towards your Transfer Balance Cap, and earnings on the account are taxed at 15% within the fund.

Once you:

- Turn 65, or
- Meet a full condition of release (such as retirement), your TRIS moves into retirement phase. At that point, it will count towards your Transfer Balance Cap and may need to be reported to the ATO through Transfer Balance Account Reporting (TBAR).

1. Who prepares and lodges a TBAR?

SuperGuardian will prepare and lodge TBARs on behalf of the fund.

2. How do I know if I need to complete a TBAR?

If you started receiving a super pension on or after 1 July 2017, a TBAR is generally required when certain pension-related events occur.

3. What is the purpose of TBARs?

TBARs allow the ATO to keep track of retirement phase pensions and ensure members stay within their Transfer Balance Cap.

4. When is a TBAR due?

Since 1 July 2023, SMSFs must report TBAR events quarterly. Reports are due 28 days after the end of the quarter in which the event occurred.

Quarter	Coverage	Due Date
Quarter 1	July to September 2026	28 October 2026
Quarter 2	October to December 2026	28 January 2027
Quarter 3	January to March 2027	28 April 2027
Quarter 4	April to June 2027	28 July 2027

5. Can my Transfer Balance Account have a negative balance?

Yes. This can happen when a pension grows in value and is later fully commuted. The debit recorded may be greater than the original credit, resulting in a negative balance.

For example:

- A pension starts on 1 July 2025 for \$1 million, resulting in a credit to the TBA, which now has a balance of \$1 million. At the time, the personal transfer balance cap is \$2,000,000 and is not fully utilised.
- Growth in assets has increased the market value to \$1.2 million at 30 June 2026 (after pension payments have been drawn). The member decides to commute the full pension back to accumulation on 01 July 2026.
- The TBA now receives a debit of \$1.2 million, resulting in a negative balance of \$200,000. (i.e. \$1,000,000-\$1,200,000)
- A new pension could now be started for up to \$2,250,000 million, incorporating the original cap of \$2 million, plus the negative balance of \$200,000 (and to be technical indexation of \$50,000).

6. What events need to be reported in a TBAR?

Common events that must be reported include:

- Starting a retirement phase pension.
- A TRIS entering retirement phase.
- Fully stopping (commuting) a pension.
- Partially stopping or commuting from a Pension account (can also be known as lump sum withdrawals from pension)
- Receiving a reversionary pension after someone's death.
- Certain divorce-related pension splits.
- Some structured settlement contributions.
- Certain limited recourse borrowing arrangement (LRBA) events.

7. How often will I need to lodge a TBAR?

Most members will only have occasional TBAR reporting obligations when significant pension events occur.

8. What if I want to withdraw more than the minimum pension?

Amounts above the minimum pension can sometimes be taken as a lump sum by partially commuting the pension. This creates a debit in the Transfer Balance Account and may free up some of the Transfer Balance Cap for future use. This is particularly important for estate planning purposes.

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